

'Well, then, monsieur, you, of whom kings ask that valuable friendship which restores crowns to them, I will venture to beg of you a little of that great interest you took in my father.'

'My lord,' replied D'Aragnan, 'believe me, I shall deem myself highly honoured if, in France, you remember having seen me here. And now permit—'

Then, turning towards the princess: 'Madam,' said he, 'your royal highness is a daughter of France; and in that quality I hope to see you again in Paris. One of my happy days will be on that on which your royal highness shall give me any command whatever, thus proving to me that you have not forgotten the recommendations of your august brother.' And he bowed respectfully to the young princess, who gave him her hand to kiss with a right royal grace.

'Ah! madam,' said Buckingham, in a subdued voice, 'what can a man do to obtain a similar favour from your royal highness?'

'Dame! my lord,' replied Henrietta, 'ask Monsieur d'Aragnan; he will tell you.'



'WHAT CAN A MAN DO TO OBTAIN A SIMILAR FAVOUR FROM YOUR ROYAL HIGHNESS?'

'You have still something to say, Parry,' replied Henrietta, smiling upon D'Arragnan, while addressing the old servant.

'Yes, madam, the king desires you to preserve religiously in your memory the name and merit of M. d'Arragnan, to whom his majesty owes, he says, the recovery of his kingdom.' Buckingham, the princess, and Rochester looked at each other.

'That,' said D'Arragnan, 'is another little secret, of which, in all probability, I shall not boast to his majesty's son, as I have done to you with respect to the diamond studs.'

'Madam,' said Buckingham, 'monsieur has just, for the second time, recalled to my memory an event which excites my curiosity to such a degree, that I shall venture to ask your permission to take him to one side for a moment, to converse in private.'

'Do, my lord,' said the princess; 'but restore to the sister, as quickly as possible, this friend so devoted to the brother.' And she took the arm of Rochester, whilst Buckingham took that of D'Arragnan.

'Oh! tell me, chevalier,' said Buckingham, 'all that affair of the diamonds, which nobody knows in England, not even the son of him who was the hero of it.'

'My lord, one person alone had a right to relate all that affair, as you call it, and that was your father; he thought it proper to be silent, I must beg you to allow me to be so likewise.' And D'Arragnan bowed like a man upon whom it was evident no entreaties could prevail.

'Since it is so, sir,' said Buckingham, 'pardon my indiscretion, I beg you; and if, at any time, I should go into France—' and he turned round to take a last look at the princess, who took but little notice of him, totally occupied as she was, or appeared to be, with Rochester. Buckingham sighed.

'Well?' said D'Arragnan.

'I was saying that if, any day, I were to go to France—'

'You will go, my lord,' said D'Arragnan, 'I shall answer for that.'

'And how so?'

'Oh, I have strange powers of prediction; if I do predict anything I am seldom mistaken. If, then, you do come to France?'

'Never mind, monsieur,' said Buckingham. 'I understand now, that, having had the intention of rendering a service to the father, you have come to claim the protection of the son.'

'In the first place, my lord,' replied D'Artagnan, phlegmatically, 'I claim the protection of no man. His majesty, Charles II, to whom I have had the honour of rendering some services—I may tell you, my lord, my life has been passed in such occupations—King Charles II, then, who wishes to honour me with some kindness, desires me to be presented to her royal highness the Princess Henrieta, his sister, to whom I shall, perhaps, have the good fortune to be of service hereafter. Now, the king knew that you at this moment were with her royal highness, and sent me to you. There is no other mystery. I ask absolutely nothing of you; and if you will not present me to her royal highness, I shall be compelled to do without you, and present myself.'

'At least, sir,' said Buckingham, determined to have the last word, 'you will not refuse me an explanation provoked by yourself.'

'I never refuse, my lord,' said D'Artagnan.

'As you have had relations with my father, you must be acquainted with some private details?'

'These relations are already far removed from us, my lord—for you were not then born—and for some unfortunate diamond studs, which I received from his hands and carried back to France, it is really not worth while awakening so many remembrances.'

'Ah! sir,' said Buckingham, warmly, going up to D'Artagnan, and holding out his hand to him, 'it is you, then—you whom my father sought everywhere and who had a right to expect so much from us.'

'To expect, my lord, in truth, that is my forte; all my life I have expected.'

At this moment, the princess, who was tired of not seeing the stranger approach her, arose and came towards them.

'At least, sir,' said Buckingham, 'you shall not wait for the presentation you claim of me.'

Then turning towards the princess and bowing: 'Madam,' said the young man, 'the king, your brother, desires me to have the honour of presenting to your royal highness, Monsieur le Chevalier d'Artagnan.'

'In order that your royal highness may have, in case of need, a firm support and a sure friend,' added Parry. D'Artagnan bowed.

Chapter XXXVI

How D'Artagnan drew a Country-Seat from a Deal Box



THE king's words regarding the wounded pride of Monk had inspired D'Artagnan with no small portion of apprehension. The lieutenant had had, all his life, the great art of choosing his enemies; and when he had found them implacable and invincible, it was when he had not been able, under any pretence, to make them otherwise. But points of view change greatly in the course of a life. It is a magic lantern, of which the eye of man every year changes the aspects. It results that from the last day of a year on which we saw white, to the first day of the year on which we shall see black, there is the interval of but a single night.

Now, D'Artagnan, when he left Calais with his ten scamps, would have hesitated as little in attacking a Goliath, a Nebuchadnezzar, or a Holofernes, as he would in crossing swords with a recruit or caviling with a land-lady. Then he resembled the sparrow-hawk, which, when fasting, will attack a ram. Hunger is blind. But D'Artagnan satisfied—D'Artagnan rich—D'Artagnan a conqueror—D'Artagnan proud of so difficult a triumph—D'Artagnan had too much to lose not to reckon, figure by figure, with probable misfortune.

His thoughts were employed, therefore, all the way on the road from his presentation, with one thing, and that was, how he should conciliate a man like Monk, a man whom Charles himself, king as he was, conciliated with difficulty; for, scarcely established, the protected might again stand in need of the protector, and would, consequently, not refuse him, such being the case, the petty satisfaction of transporting M. d'Artagnan, or of confining him in

one of the Middlesex prisons, or drowning him a little on his passage from Dover to Boulogne. Such sorts of satisfaction kings are accustomed to render to viceroys without disagreeable consequences.

It would not be at all necessary for the king to be active in that contrepartie of the play in which Monk should take his revenge. The part of the king would be confined to simply pardoning the viceroy of Ireland all he should undertake against D'Arragnan. Nothing more was necessary to place the conscience of the Duke of Albemarle at rest than a *te absolvo* said with a laugh, or the scrawl of 'Charles the King,' traced at the foot of a parchment; and with these two words pronounced, and these two words written, poor D'Arragnan was forever crushed beneath the ruins of his imagination.

And then, a thing sufficiently disquieting for a man with such foresight as our musketeer, he found himself alone; and even the friendship of Athos could not restore his confidence. Certainly if the affair had only concerned a free distribution of sword-thrusts, the musketeer would have counted upon his companion; but in delicate dealings with a king, when the perhaps of an unlucky chance should arise in justification of Monk or of Charles of England, D'Arragnan knew Athos well enough to be sure he would give the best possible colouring to the loyalty of the survivor, and would content himself with shedding floods of tears on the tomb of the dead, supposing the dead to be his friend, and afterwards composing his epitaph in the most pompous superlatives.

'Decidedly,' thought the Gascon; and this thought was the result of the reflections which he had just whispered to himself and which we have repeated aloud—'decidedly, I must be reconciled with M. Monk, and acquire proof of his perfect indifference for the past. If, and God forbid it should be so! he is still sulky and reserved in the expression of this sentiment, I shall give my money to Athos to take away with him, and remain in England just long enough to unmask him, then, as I have a quick eye and a light foot, I shall notice the first hostile sign; to decamp or conceal myself at the residence of my lord Buckingham, who seems a good sort of devil at the bottom, and to whom, in return for his hospitality, I shall relate all that history of the diamonds, which can now compromise nobody but an old queen, who need not be ashamed, after being the wife of a miserly creature like Mazarin, of having formerly been the mistress of a handsome nobleman like Buckingham. *Mordieu!* that is

The young man, who considered this order as a favour, resumed his courage, and hastened to meet Parry, who, followed by D'Arragnan, advanced slowly on account of his age. D'Arragnan walked slowly but nobly, as D'Arragnan, doubled by the third of a million, ought to walk, that is to say, without conceit or swagger, but without timidity. When Buckingham, very eager to comply with the desire of the princess, who had seated herself on a marble bench, as if fatigued with the few steps she had gone,—when Buckingham, we say, was at a distance of only a few paces from Parry, the latter recognized him.

'Ah! my lord!' cried he, quite out of breath, 'will your grace obey the king?'

'In what, Mr Parry?' said the young man, with a kind of coolness tempered by a desire to make himself agreeable to the princess.

'Well, his majesty begs your grace to present this gentleman to her royal highness the Princess Henrietta.'

'In the first place, what is the gentleman's name?' said the duke, haughtily.

D'Arragnan, as we know, was easily affronted, and the Duke of Buckingham's tone displeased him. He surveyed the courier from head to foot, and two flashes beamed from beneath his bent brows. But, after a struggle,—

'Monsieur le Chevalier d'Arragnan, my lord,' replied he, quietly.

'Pardon me, sir, that teaches me your name, but nothing more.'

'You mean—'

'I mean I do not know you.'

'I am more fortunate than you, sir,' replied D'Arragnan, 'for I have had the honour of knowing your family, and particularly my lord Duke of Buckingham, your illustrious father.'

'My father?' said Buckingham. 'Well, I think I now remember. Monsieur le Chevalier d'Arragnan, do you say?'

D'Arragnan bowed. 'In person,' said he.

'Pardon me, but are you one of those Frenchmen who had secret relations with my father?'

'Exactly, my lord duke, I am one of those Frenchmen.'

'Then, sir, permit me to say that it was strange my father never heard of you during his lifetime.'

'No, monsieur, but he heard of me at the moment of his death: it was I who sent to him, through the hands of the valet de chambre of Anne of Austria, notice of the dangers which threatened him; unfortunately, it came too late.'

Parry wants to speak to me, I believe: please order them to row to the shore, my Lord Rochester.'

Rochester hastened to repeat the princess's command, and a moment later the boat touched the bank.

'Let us land, gentlemen,' said Henrietta, taking the arm which Rochester offered her, although Buckingham was nearer to her, and had presented his. Then Rochester, with an ill-dissembled pride, which pierced the heart of the unhappy Buckingham through and through, led the princess across the little bridge which the rowers had cast from the royal boat to the shore.

'Which way will your highness go?' asked Rochester.

'You see, my lord, towards that good Parry, who is wandering, as my lord of Buckingham says, and seeking me with eyes weakened by the tears he has shed over our misfortunes.'

'Good heavens!' said Rochester, 'how sad your royal highness is to-day; in truth we seem ridiculous fools to you, madam.'

'Speak for yourself, my lord,' interrupted Buckingham with vexation; 'for my part, I displease her royal highness to such a degree, that I appear absolutely nothing to her.'

Neither Rochester nor the princess made any reply; Henrietta only urged her companion more quickly on. Buckingham remained behind, and took advantage of this isolation to give himself up to his anger; he bit his handkerchief so furiously that it was soon in shreds.

'Parry, my good Parry,' said the princess, with her gentle voice, 'come hither. I see you are seeking me, and I am waiting for you.'

'Ah, madam,' said Rochester, coming charitably to the help of his companion, who had remained, as we have said, behind, 'if Parry cannot see your royal highness, the man who follows him is a sufficient guide, even for a blind man; for he has eyes of flame. That man is a double-lamped lantern.'

'Lighting a very handsome martial countenance,' said the princess, determined to be as ill-natured as possible. Rochester bowed. 'One of those vigorous soldiers' heads seen nowhere but in France,' added the princess, with the perseverance of a woman sure of impunity.

Rochester and Buckingham looked at each other, as much as to say,—'What can be the matter with her?'

'See, my lord of Buckingham, what Parry wants,' said Henrietta. 'Go!'

the thing, and this Monk shall not get the better of me. Eh? and besides I have an idea!

We know that, in general, D'Artagnan was not wanting in ideas; and during this soliloquy, D'Artagnan buttoned his vest up to the chin, and nothing excited his imagination like this preparation for a combat of any kind, called ac-cinction by the Romans. He was quite heated when he reached the mansion of the Duke of Albemarle. He was introduced to the viceroys with a promptitude which proved that he was considered as one of the household. Monk was in his business-closet.

'My lord,' said D'Artagnan, with that expression of frankness which the Gascon knew so well how to assume, 'my lord, I have come to ask your grace's advice!'

Monk, as closely buttoned up morally as his antagonist was physically, replied: 'Ask, my friend,' and his countenance presented an expression not less open than that of D'Artagnan.

'My lord, in the first place, promise me secrecy and indulgence.'

'I promise you all you wish. What is the matter? Speak!'

'It is, my lord, that I am not quite pleased with the king.'

'Indeed! And on what account, my dear lieutenant?'

'Because his majesty gives way sometimes to jests very compromising for his servants; and jesting, my lord, is a weapon that seriously wounds men of the sword, as we are.'

Monk did all in his power not to betray his thought, but D'Artagnan watched him with too close attention not to detect an almost imperceptible flush upon his face. 'Well, now, for my part,' said he, with the most natural air possible, 'I am not an enemy of jesting, my dear Monsieur d'Artagnan; my soldiers will tell you that even many times in camp, I listened very indifferently, and with a certain pleasure, to the satirical songs which the army of Lambert passed into mine, and which, certainly, would have caused the ears of a general more susceptible than I am to tingle.'

'Oh, my lord,' said D'Artagnan, 'I know you are a complete man; I know you have been, for a long time, placed above human miseries; but there are jests and jests of a certain kind, which have the power of irritating me beyond expression.'

'May I inquire what kind, my friend?'

‘Such as are directed against my friends or against people I respect, my lord!’ Monk made a slight movement, which D’Artagnan perceived. ‘Eh! and in what,’ asked Monk, ‘in what can the stroke of a pin which scratches another tickle your skin? Answer me that.’

‘My lord, I can explain it to you in a single sentence; it concerns you.’

Monk advanced a single step towards D’Artagnan. ‘Concerns me?’ said he.

‘Yes, and this is what I cannot explain; but that arises, perhaps, from my want of knowledge of his character. How can the king have the heart to jest about a man who has rendered him so many and such great services? How can one understand that he should amuse himself in setting by the ears a lion like you with a gnat like me?’

‘I cannot conceive that in any way,’ said Monk.

‘But so it is. The king, who owed me a reward, might have rewarded me as a soldier, without contriving that history of the ransom, which affects you, my lord.’

‘No,’ said Monk, laughing: ‘it does not affect me in any way, I can assure you.’

‘Not as regards me, I can understand; you know me, my lord, I am so discreet that the grave would appear a babbler compared to me; but—do you understand, my lord?’

‘No,’ replied Monk, with persistent obstinacy.

‘If another knew the secret which I know—’

‘What secret?’

‘Eh! my lord, why, that unfortunate secret of Newcastle.’

‘Oh! the million of the Comte de la Fère?’

‘No, my lord, no; the enterprise made upon your grace’s person.’

‘It was well played, chevalier, that is all, and no more is to be said about it: you are a soldier, both brave and cunning, which proves that you unite the qualities of Fabius and Hannibal. You employed your means, force and cunning: there is nothing to be said against that: I ought to have been on guard.’

‘Ah! yes; I know, my lord, and I expected nothing less from your partiality; so that if it were only the abduction in itself, *Mordieux!* that would be nothing; but there are—’

‘What?’

she turned from the young nobles to wander over the green and flowery turf of the park, when she perceived Parry and D’Artagnan at a distance.

‘Who is coming yonder?’ said she.

The two young men turned round with the rapidity of lightning.

‘Parry,’ replied Buckingham; ‘nobody but Parry.’

‘I beg your pardon,’ said Rochester, ‘but I think he has a companion.’

‘Yes,’ said the princess, at first with languor, but then, — ‘What mean those words, “Nobody but Parry,” say, my lord?’

‘Because, madam,’ replied Buckingham, piqued, ‘because the faithful Parry, the wandering Parry, the eternal Parry, is not, I believe, of much consequence.’

‘You are mistaken, duke. Parry—the wandering Parry, as you call him—has always wandered in the service of my family, and the sight of that old man always gives me satisfaction.’

The Lady Henrietta followed the usual progress of pretty women, particularly coquettish women; she passed from caprice to contradiction;—the gallant had undergone the caprice, the courtier must bend beneath the contradictory humour. Buckingham bowed, but made no reply.

‘It is true, madam,’ said Rochester, bowing in his turn, ‘that Parry is the model of servants; but, madam, he is no longer young, and we laugh only when we see cheerful objects. Is an old man a gay object?’

‘Enough, my lord,’ said the princess, coolly; ‘the subject of conversation is unpleasant to me.’

Then, as if speaking to herself, ‘It is really unaccountable,’ said she, ‘how little regard my brother’s friends have for his servants.’

‘Ah, madam,’ cried Buckingham, ‘your royal highness pierces my heart with a dagger forged by your own hands.’

‘What is the meaning of that speech, which is turned so like a French madrigal, duke? I do not understand it.’

‘It means, madam, that you yourself, so good, so charming, so sensible, you have laughed sometimes—smiled, I should say—at the idle prattle of that good Parry, for whom your royal highness to-day entertains such a marvellous susceptibility.’

‘Well, my lord, if I have forgotten myself so far,’ said Henrietta, ‘you do wrong to remind me of it.’ And she made a sign of impatience. ‘The good